

THE RHYTHM CODE MAP

16 positions · 3 states · the complete guide to where stops should land

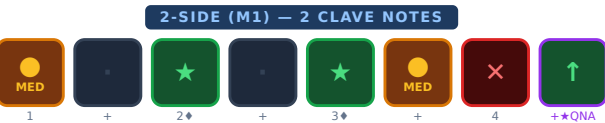
BEYOND THE CLAVE

The clave has 5 notes. But there are 16 positions. What about the other 11?

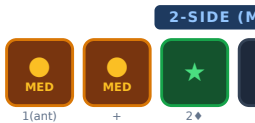
The Rhythm Code maps ALL 16 positions across two measures. Three states: **STRONG** (ideal stop positions) · **MEDIUM** (occasional) · **AVOID** (weak positions for stops)

- ★ **STRONG** — ideal stop position. Clave notes and quarter note anticipation.
- **MEDIUM** — acceptable. Occasional stops OK.
- ✕ **AVOID** — weak. Stops here sound awkward.
- ◼ Empty downbeat position
- ◼ Empty upbeat position

2-3 ORIENTATION MAP



3-2 ORIENTATION MAP



KEY INSIGHTS FROM THE MAP

2-Side Structure

THREE strong positions on the 2-side: the two clave notes (beat 2 and beat 3) plus the quarter note anticipation at "and of 4." The 2-side is rhythmically rich.

3-Side Structure

TWO strong positions on the 3-side: the clave notes that are NOT the first beat. The first beat of the 3-side is usually anticipated — felt as beat 1 but arrived early from "and of 4."

Quarter Note Anticipation (↑)

Position 8 ("and of 4") in BOTH orientations is STRONG. This is the quarter note anticipation — the most powerful single position in the Rhythm Code. Set a stop here whenever possible.

HOW TO USE THE MAP

1

Identify the clave orientation of your song (2-3 or 3-2)

2

Transcribe the main melody or bass line in the binary grid

3

Find all stops — overlay the Rhythm Code map

4

Move stops at AVOID (✕) positions one step to an upbeat

★

"It's a guide, not a rule — if it sounds good, it IS good."